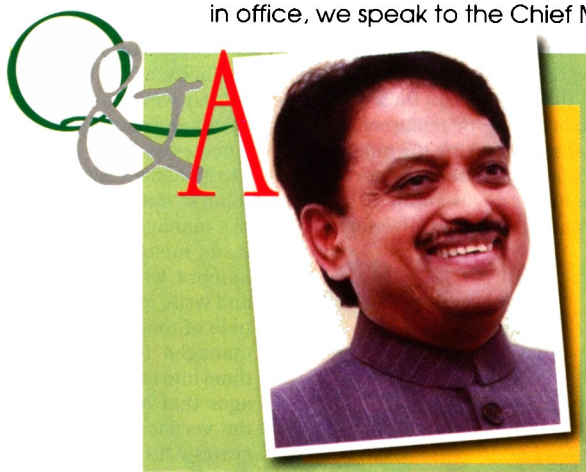


Maharashtra: *Numero Uno*

The driving force behind the Democratic Front Government in Maharashtra, Chief Minister Vilasrao Deshmukh has taken the State on the path of progress by initiating successful development projects across the State. A dynamic leader with three decades of experience in Maharashtra politics, Vilasrao Deshmukh is well known for his administrative and organisational skills. From initiating infrastructure development projects to introducing agriculture-friendly policies, the Chief Minister has a list of achievements to his credit. On the fourth anniversary of his Government in office, we speak to the Chief Minister on his vision for Maharashtra.



Shri Vilasrao Deshmukh
Hon'ble Chief Minister of Maharashtra

Q. How does the Maharashtra Government plan to address the issues of affordable housing for the 'Aam Admi'?

A. The Central and State Governments are planning to build 10 lakh houses in the next two years. A total investment of more than Rs. 5,000 crore is being done under various schemes. There are schemes undertaken by the Maharashtra Housing and Area Development Authority (MHADA), the Jawaharlal Nehru National Urban Renewal Mission (JNNURM), and Rajiv Gandhi Grameen Nivara Yojana to address the problem of housing in urban as well as rural areas. These low-cost housing will come up in Mumbai, Aurangabad, Nanded, Nagpur, Kolhapur and various other districts in the State.

Q. How will the State, and particularly Mumbai, stand to benefit under JNNURM?

A. Many important cities will be covered under the JNNURM. There are 51 projects that are being implemented in these districts. Maharashtra State has received funds worth Rs. 7,528 crore under this scheme. This is the first time that any State has taken an initiative to concentrate on the urban areas. In Maharashtra, the urbanization rate is much higher than other States since more than 50 per cent of the population lives in cities. Since Mumbai is plagued with the problem of water supply, various initiatives like the 'BRIMSTOWAD' project are being undertaken. Also various roads and flyovers are being constructed under this scheme.

Q. What about development of special minority groups like women?

A. The State has recently introduced a special interest rate scheme for Women Self-Help Groups. Under this scheme they can avail loans at the interest rate of 4 per cent and the difference will be paid by the Government from its budget. More than two lakh such groups in the State stand to benefit from this initiative.

Q. What initiatives is the Government taking to generate employment in the State?

A. The State of Maharashtra ranks #1 in the wine business. Ichalkaranji and Kolhapur are considered the textile hubs, while Mumbai is retail hub, so we are going to get maximum investment in these areas. This will boost the employment in the State. As per the State policy it has to employ 80 per cent of the local population in these initiatives. As an added advantage, the Government is also planning to create finishing schools that will train graduates and other diploma holders to hone their skills.

Q. Has the Maharashtra Government focused on holistic development of the State where backward groups are not left out?

A. We have identified backlog in areas like roads, irrigation, education, health, etc. Special funds are being allocated by the Governor for these projects. The State is looking at an equitable distribution of funds to overcome the backlog. Ours is the first State to introduce the Special Component Plan. Under this, if the Scheduled Caste forms 11 per cent of the total population in the State, then that percentage of the State budget will be allocated for their development and benefit. The same applies for the Scheduled Tribes. A budget of Rs. 3,400 crore has been allocated for the SC and ST. The Government has also set up the Special Minorities Department which has a budget of Rs. 160 crore. This department has taken up various schemes to uplift the status of the minorities and education will form an important part of this initiative. As far as technical, medical, professional, agriculture and polytechnic education is concerned various private and Government colleges are being introduced. For the Economically Backward groups especially the SC and ST the Government is providing free education. Also 50 per cent fees for the OBC and Other Economically Backward students are being paid by the Government through various schemes. To tackle health problems, the National Rural Health Mission is being implemented in the State. We are also providing good infrastructure and appointing doctors in the tribal and backward areas.

Q. How are you planning to help the farmers in the backward regions?

A. There are various ways in which we are helping farmers. They are being granted loans at an interest rate of 6 per cent by banks. The State Government will pay the difference in the interest rates to the banks on their behalf. An additional subsidy of 2 per cent has been announced for the benefit of farmers if they repay loan on time.

Q. What are the special plans being introduced for Mumbai in particular?

A. A grant of Rs.1,200 crore has been given to the State Government for the 'BRIMSTOWAD' project. There is another interesting project in the pipeline called the Mumbai Metro Region (MMR) plan worth \$60 billion. It will cover regions like Thane and Raigad apart from Mumbai. It is expected to be completed by 2020. The 'aam aadmi' can expect 50 skywalks to come up in a year at major traffic areas in the city. The Dharavi makeover plan of more than Rs. 10,000 crore is another important plan in the pipeline that will change the face of the city.

Q. Keeping in mind the infrastructure development projects initiated by the Government, by when will people of Mumbai be able to reap the benefits of these initiatives?